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Byron Stripling Part II
(The Covid Interview)

The Covid-19 pandemic impacted the music and arts community particularly hard. Musicians who had previously been interviewed for the Fillius Jazz Archive graciously shared their experiences during this virtual shutdown period. The political and racial unrest occurring simultaneously was also addressed.

Byron was interviewed via Zoom on June 25, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College, and I'm very pleased to re-connect with Byron Stripling, who did a memorable series of shows for me 22 years ago. I think we both look exactly the same.

BS: I think I got prettier.

MR: Just before I hit the record button we were talking about, I'm just looking for a gig. Do you want to expand on that?

BS: Well it goes to the pandemic and Covid actually. Musicians always joke about that, and you know, the question is when the phone rings, the joke is when the phone rings I just pick up the phone and say, "I can do it." You know? And that's the thing. That's the joke. And we don't do that, because there's a lot of parameters that you want for any time that you work. But the unfortunate part of where we're at in terms on being in Covid-19 and dealing with this is that nobody is gonna call you. And that can be tragic for a musician because the one thing that you can do, you can't do it. And I smile out of my pain, but the one thing that — I can play for people. I can sing for them, I can make people happy. I mean I honestly feel kind of like we're put here as musicians to make people happy. I feel that the theater is a magical place, a place where people can go and — remember that old song "Forget your troubles, come on get happy" right? That's what music does for people. It's a chance for people to go into the theater and get that experience. And I and my friends, that's what we do. And now we're placed in a situation where we can't do what we do because people will die if we do it, you know, if they come together. And so that's just been a difficult thing to grasp, I mean imagine having two kids in college and you can't do what you can do. And then, you know, you look at the inequities of some people do great during a pandemic. If you're Amazon, you know, great. You can deliver stuff right to their house you know? I can't do that. You know if you're a grocery store you can raise your prices if you want to because you know that people have to come to

store. If you're a restaurant that's not going to happen. If you're Small's in New York City — I mean I live in Columbus, Ohio, but I'm reading about what's happening to the clubs, Small's, Mezzro is another one, and the rent people are like, "We don't care if you can't have people in the nightclub. Where's my money?" So these are unfortunate circumstances.

MR: Do you feel like in addition to the loss of income do you feel sort of like a loss of identity?

BS: Not really. Maybe to answer the same question, loss of relevance, because musicians and artists always question their relevance, especially as a jazz musician, when you realize that jazz is the lowest selling music. You know rap is number one. My kids just showed me tonight have you heard of this group K-Pop?

MR: Um hum.

BS: It's an all-Asian young kids and stuff, and you know, I look at John Coltrane's "A Love Supreme" on YouTube 'cause sometimes I'll just put stuff on YouTube as I'm cooking or something, I'll put on "A Love Supreme." And maybe it'll have 50,000 views. And I see five kids dancing around going [scats] and you know they've got a billion — and I've never seen that on a YouTube. So I know that the music I play is amazing, it's important to me, but you start to question your relevance as, you know, hey, you know, I've got some videos on YouTube too you know. I don't need a billion, but can I get a couple likes? So you start to question that. It's part of being an artist. And every artist goes through it. Judy Garland was never happy unless she was onstage. And I have that too. My wife has indicated it, that sometimes — and this has been a difficult time — my wife will sometimes say if I have like three or four days where I don't work she'll like, "You need to go out and just play somewhere. Just get out of the house because you're bugging me." Because she knows that I get nourished by playing music. And she can't even tell me that now, right?

MR: What happened with your teaching? Did you have to go online with private students and so forth?

BS: So I do teach at the Manhattan School of Music, and I've always not wanted to be — to take a teaching position, I just always wanted to play. It's unfortunate, I always have a ton of gigs that I play, and it just happened that last September their professor at the last minute got a better gig and they said, "Hey we've got a space we need to fill," and they've been asking me for years, "could you come out — we'll limit the amount of students, it won't be hard." So I taught through the first semester and I was supposed to teach the second semester — right in the middle of March they said, "We're all done, school is closing, you need to teach your lessons via Zoom." I'd never heard of Zoom.

do computer stuff, and then thankfully I have daughters that know that stuff. They're in their twenties, and so they showed me the light, but it wasn't a hard thing to learn. So my teaching all went online. It was not a fun thing to do because I felt I was ripping people off. I need to have that one-on-one contact with them. I need to hear your sound. I need to hear your attack.

MR: Right. Not through the airwaves and whatever Zoom —

BS: I worked with John Clayton, the great bassist, and he told me some things to do to tweak the settings on Zoom. He said, "Get a mic, a separate mic, your computer mic isn't adequate." And all the teachers kind of got together and sort of helped each other and coached each other as to what they need. But literally, when you play a trumpet towards your computer it tries to, I forget what they call it, balance it. Compress it. So I'd be — when I first started my Zoom lessons like [scats] and it would just get this thing and it would go down and then you couldn't hear anything. It's trying to control that sound. And so we worked through that stuff, but that's been the challenge too, the teaching online.

MR: What about the motivation of the students? Did you get a sense of where they're at?

BS: Yeah. So in talking with other faculty members, we all agreed that it was important to talk to the kids about what they're feeling too, not just, you can't ignore that. And one thing about being — and that's the other reason I never wanted to teach privately like this, because I feel it's a big responsibility. It wasn't arrogance on my part, it was me — when I taught at Manhattan School of Music for instance, I just didn't feel I could give the kind of time because I was going out of town. And so what I did with these lessons is I only taught on Mondays and Tuesdays, and by then I would go out of town for my gigs. What was your original question?

MR: Well I had to do almost the exact same scenario and some of the students seem to work well in the format and others didn't and I wondered just how do you motivate them?

BS: Right. So good question. What I was saying is, where I was going with that is I felt also I began each lesson with five, ten minutes max if I could, just, how are you feeling? How is this affecting you? Because that's going to affect how you play, your desire to practice and everything. Some kids were isolated. They hadn't left — they were scared to leave their room — some kids I had to say maybe you don't need to go out as often. You know? So everybody was dealing with a mental thing. So I thought it was good to address that for five or ten minutes. And for some it went even longer as to what they were dealing with personally. Then once we got to that, then I got on track with the music. And what I've always done with music is let the music be the motivator. There are other — so if I can introduce somebody to Clifford Brown playing "Donna Lee" and let's

each particular — what got each particular student energized and motivated. And so a quick aside to that is for young people I've been finding, maybe you found this, that if the person is living then they're more apt to be attracted to it. I don't know if you've gotten that. So check it out. So I'll tell somebody hey, bring — I want to have them do what they want to do first. I say, "Bring in a transcribed solo, anybody you want to, let's work on it next week. Write it out a little bit if you can, if you can memorize it without writing it out fine but bring in something and we'll work on that. And people would bring in Roy Hargrove and Tom Harrell and Terrell Stafford, and all people that I love, right? And I would sort of nudge them like, "Hey you know, you want to try Dizzy next time?" And it was like, but I've got these guys. And I talked to my wife who is very smart, and I said, "Why is that?" And she goes, "Byron, you knew Dizzy Gillespie. You met Miles Davis. You saw Roy Eldridge play a bunch of times. You didn't see Louis. You saw and sat next to Freddie Hubbard and played with him. Just go down the list. That's what they're looking for." So for some — this is not all people — and eventually they get to like, "Oh I transcribed Roy Hargrove and it sounds like Miles, maybe I need to check out Miles." So it's just an interesting way. So that's what I did for motivation. But also finally is practicing. Because I had a student, you know, tell me like, yeah, he played the thing, he's like, "Sorry I didn't have a chance to practice." And I'm like, "You don't think I know that? I can hear that. I know." I'm not like one of these guys, but I know when you haven't practiced so just know that you can't fake it for me. And we can just be honest with each other. And I understand there's times when you can't practice. So I did use an approach with a friend of mine, Shawn "Thunder" Wallace. A great sax player. He's the head of the department at Ohio State University. And he said, "Make them keep a practice log, and log in and just have them, they need to show you that." Now you can lie on that too, but it's tougher. Because you're telling me you practiced every day for an hour on this exercise and these things and that's where you're at? I don't believe that. So it's harder to lie.

MR: It takes me back to fifth grade when you used to put down, you know, this day, and then your parents were supposed to sign it.

BS: Right. Exactly. Exactly. Well I guess you become your own parent when you get in college so.

MR: Well speaking of the music business I looked at our interview from 1998, and there was this lovely story you told about your parents and your father would call you, like what are you doing today, and you might say, "Well the last couple of days I was at Hamilton College but today I have nothing." And he would say, "Well you need to get a job." So my question is what is your advice to students now about the music business. And maybe

it's pre-Covid. I don't know if this pandemic should actually affect what you tell students yet. That was a long phrased question, but —

BS: Oh no. It's a great question. First of all actually what I had to discuss with my father was even better than what you described. He would say, "I know you were at Carnegie Hall last night" and I appreciated it. He and my mother. And I know that you played on a record date and you know, I was so lucky when I lived in New York, I was doing so much. What I would say to kids about that part of your life to and explaining it to your parents is, those challenges are good. It's good to be able to defend what you're doing. When I told my mother, I'll never forget it, we lived on Wood Creek Court I think it was, in Texas. And I said, "Mom, I'm going to move to New York." And she started crying. She was like, "Why don't you go back and get your degree?" And this and that. And I had to explain what my vision was for that. And it's good that I had to do that. You need to be able to tell people what you're going to do and your strategy. For you to be able to verbalize that not only helps them understand you but it's for you. You need to outline what path you're going to take. Sometimes you don't know that path and you're on faith and you can say that too. Say I don't know what it is but in my gut I know I need to be around the musicians that I've adored all my life. And sometimes that's enough but if you can add to it you can. I'll give you a quick story of somebody else. Do you know Dick Oatts, the great sax player? He's a great alto player. Yeah. So Dick said he worked with Thad Jones at University of Minnesota. That's where I first met Thad Jones, I lived in Minnesota. And Thad loved him. He said, "Man you sound great." He says, "Look if you ever move to New York give me a call." He was like wow, cool. So he flew into LaGuardia Airport about a year later and there was a pay phone there at LaGuardia Airport and he goes, "Hey Thad, I'm here." But now here's where it gets crazy. Thad goes, "Oh man, I remember you, Minnesota, alto player." He said, "What are you doing tonight?" And Dick said, "Nothing." He says, "We need a second alto" or something. This is like when he lands in LaGuardia from Minnesota. You know? So he went and I said, "How was that first night?" Here's the funny part of the story. He goes, well — I don't know if you ever saw the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis band but it was an amazing band that was totally spontaneous. It was also like a party many times, what they did on the bandstand. It was good times and just fun. And you never knew what Thad was going to do. I remember myself seeing that band a lot. He'd just cut off the whole band and Janice Robinson would just play trombone with her plunger, and then Thad would join her and they would talk with their plungers you know. And it was like you knew that they were swearing and arguing and telling jokes with their instruments. So anyway Dick was like I wonder if he's going to give me a solo. And at one point he went like this [gestures] stand

that's jazz and that's, you know, but anyway Dick had that same vision of going to New York and making it and that was his first night. Certain people aren't so lucky. I walked into New York and I had a Broadway show when I decided to permanently move there. Certainly I can talk to you about other things people can do and in fact in regard to what people should do now as opposed to before Covid or after, the music is still going to be there. It's still going to be great music, but we have to adapt ourselves to the sort of new way of delivering it. Most people are already on that tract if you're familiar with Bria Skonberg.

MR: Um hum. I've heard her.

BS: Benny Benack, there's a guy named Tony Glausi, these are three trumpet players that are on it. Their social media presence is strong, they post almost every day or every other day with something. It's informative and they're great musicians and they're good people. And I suggest to people to follow those kind of examples of what it's going to feel like, be like and look like in the future.

MR: All right. Do you have any feeling about why in 2020, or this time in our history, that this pandemic occurred?

BS: Yes. Because God, if you believe in God, whatever you believe, if God wants to give you a gift he wraps it in a problem. And so I think we've been given a gift and we've been made to look at ourselves and look at our actions, and we can either see and learn the lessons from those, but we've had problems all this whole time that we've ignored. And there's a saying that says that problem that you have is now two, is now three, because you ignored it, now four because you ignored it. And it begins to grow exponentially. And that's like with the protests and things that we have, because Covid obviously has not only exposed bare our weaknesses in healthcare, I mean it makes no sense that people could get sick and lose their job and then have the burden to worry if they could pay to get themselves well. Screw GoFundMe. Why should you have to raise money so you can breathe, right? So this is what we're dealing with. So we've ignored these problems, and problems always come back to you. So now we've been given this gift that pulled the covers off of the whole thing. It pulled it off racism, because people had a chance to sort of bathe in it and then we had a president that stoked it and lit a fire and threw flames and stuff on it, and so the expectation is you're just going to sit there? No we're going to go out and do what we've always done, we're going to protest and let people know what these feelings are. And then people will try to misconstrue what you're thinking and how you're doing, what you're doing. And they'll make lies up about you and the guy goes and kneels because he wants to protest police violence. And you say, "You're just an athlete" and then what's the great basketball player, LeBron James, makes a statement

your response? So one thing about artists is we do have feelings. And we express them generally through music but we also — it's necessary for us to take a stand verbally and to language through our art but also verbally. So "shut up and dribble" that's slave stuff. Right? When somebody tells you, "Yeah you guys get beaten when you get stopped by the police, that's 'cause you're not acting like you're supposed to act." You know how they want you to act? Like a slave. "Yessir boss, I's sorry. Here's my license." That's the attitude that they would want you to do. I was stopped with a dear friend, my dear friend who is white. We were driving to the International Trumpet Guild in Texas. He's from Texas. He was driving. Going to see the Trumpet Guild. He was going too fast. We knew it, we wanted to get there and go see the — and I said I knew it was going to happen. And I won't say his name because he'd be embarrassed for me telling the story. But we laugh about it together. The policeman pulls us both over. I was just like okay, just be cool, just be cool. He goes, "No, no, I'll be right back." And he jumped out of the car and ran back to the policeman. I'm like, "What are you doing? What are you doing you know?" So I'm sitting there on pins and needles. I mean this is probably twenty years ago, which wouldn't have mattered racially on my case. So he ran back and he was back in about two minutes. And I said — and he goes "Okay we're good, let's go." I said, "What just happened?" you know, as we were driving away. He said, "I told him we were in a hurry." Great. I mean I couldn't have done that. So what all of this stuff, and I apologize for talking about this stuff but I think it's where the pandemic has brought us. What all of this stuff brings up is me. I don't have a real take on being affected by racism in a way a lot of other people have. But I do know that I've made a goal to walk every day of the pandemic. I have no excuses, Monk. There was nothing I could say, oh I don't have time, right. Exactly. So I said I've got to walk every day. And I've only missed like four days, because I got busy with stuff. So that's been a pretty good record. Problem was the more uprising and my wife and I watched George Floyd get assassinated on TV by somebody's knee. My wife said I don't want you to walk unless I'm with you. I don't think that's a reality that most people have to think about, but I do as a black man. And it's nothing I want people to feel sorry for me or I just think it's something that exists for me, that every time when I do walk and there happens to be a police car coming by, I'm very nervous about it. And that's a reality for me. And I think I need to be. And I will be respectful if I get stopped, but I've seen videos that tells me that that doesn't matter. So the pandemic has brought up all these things which were always there simmering under there. And us jazz musicians from Louis Armstrong to Coltrane to Don Cherry and Ornette and from the current day guys and Wynton and all those guys, we've all experienced that and we've all tried to sort of dampen it down with our music. But

You can play your horn. Sing for me boy. But they don't want you to have an opinion about something. And I've got opinions. And my opinions aren't wrong.

MR: Human nature is scary sometimes and I wonder how we change — what has to change first, the attitude or is it something that just has to be legislated? That you can't get away with acting like that anymore.

BS: I think — I like your language of legislating but it's interesting I was working with a friend of mine that's a lawyer. I had gotten this contract for a gig and it had all this crazy language in it about what I was supposed to do. And he goes, "It appears they don't trust you." He said, "And you can't write trust in a contract." The things that you and I are talking about now, they can't be legislated or put in a contract. They have to come from the heart. And as we've talked about this being a problem, you have to agree that there is a problem before you can begin to solve it, and I think that we're at that point is that can we agree that something happened? Can we agree that — and I'll go deep and dark now — can we agree that people, black people were hung from trees. Sweets Edison told me, he says, "You know when I used to walk by white women I would always look at my shoes because I didn't want anybody to say 'You're looking at that white woman.'" Because I'd seen the lynchings. And so can we agree that lynchings happened? Some people will tell you the Holocaust didn't happen. That's how deep it gets, all right? So can we agree that lynchings happened? And can we agree that when they happened people would gather to watch those lynchings? And can we agree that I have pictures of people putting their kids on their shoulders to watch those things? And can we agree if you look at the audiences in those pictures that people were smiling and grinning? Can we agree that they would cut people's fingers off and put them in jars and put them in the thing that preserves it, and they would sell them. They say, "You want a souvenir from the lynching?" Can we agree that people made postcards from the lynchings and on the back of one of them they wrote, "This was the bar-b-que that we had tonight." Can I go even deeper and can we agree that there was this curiosity about the black man's sexual prowess and so not only would you be lynched but before the lynching they would take your penis and cut it off and castrate you and many times stick it in your mouth. That's a legacy that people don't want to deal with. They want to tell you, boy you just need to be quiet when the policeman stops you. And as I said before, you could even be quiet, you still might get shot. So I think how do we begin to have uncomfortable conversations, crucial conversations. And I don't want sympathy. I personally don't want reparations. Because to me what reparations are, what they should be if there's reparations, it's just equality. So that the people in Kentucky don't have to go 600,000 to one polling place. That's the reparations I want. I want as many polling places as naturally accommodate

MR: Maybe it's the news that I choose to watch and the polls, but it seems like the majority of the country now feels like that. And it's a minority that's keeping the country down and with terrible intentions.

BS: Yeah I mean I think it depends on, that's why social media does us no good. Because if we just have our circle of friends we only see what they post. If you just watch CNN you only see what they say about these issues. When we had the Trump election, nobody had Trump signs in our neighborhood. All those people voted for Trump. And I don't know who they're going to vote for this time. But all my friends voted for Trump. And that's what they did and I have some nice neighbors. I love my neighbors. I have a few that didn't. And to that point, those are the ones that I have conversations with. And finally to your point, it's not all bleak, I walked down — I live in a very Republican neighborhood. I walked down the street the other day when I was on my morning walk and there was a guy that had a Black Lives Matter sign on his lawn. But across the street from him, on the other side, there's a flag that says Trump 2020. So you know I don't know who is voting for who. My wife couldn't get out of bed — I don't mean to talk politics but actually at this point it doesn't matter because it appears from the actions of our president, he's shown us, you know, that we need to talk about this. So I have to talk about that. And I apologize for talking about it.

MR: I appreciate your eloquent opinions. Just to wrap up, were you in the position, when all the cancellations of gigs started coming in, usually you were told, okay the gig is off, the thing is cancelled. Did you have to cancel anything yourself, out of feeling for your own protection or the thinking of your sidemen or whatever else?

BS: Well yeah I had a number of scenarios in that, so I conduct the Columbus Jazz Orchestra and the week that the State of Ohio, the governor did a great thing and the day before our first concert he said no venues of a thousand or more can have people there. Our concerts run four nights: Thursday, Friday, Saturday and Sunday. I had two guest artists in and my full band had already done four rehearsals with those guest artists to present the concert. On Thursday, the day we were supposed to start, the governor said, actually venues, only 500 was the max you could have in your venue. That cut us out. We were rehearsing when we got that, we were onstage at our theater. We had dinner for everybody between sound check and shows. And during dinner I just talked to everybody and the one thing I did say is I said when we come back from this things will never be the same. So we cancelled all our performances — real quick, it goes to your question — we said okay well how about, we got everybody agree to do a live broadcast on FaceBook on Saturday and we found a venue that seated only 50 people, which was allowable back then at the very beginning, or in the middle of March. We go there, one of my musicians said, "Hey

with has a horrible fever right now. I just wanted to let you know that." And that's when they were just starting to talk about what you need to watch out for and that was one of the things. He said, "I feel fine but I could be one of those asymptomatic guys." And you know I just weighed that, and it was like we can't do this. We can't put those people on stage. Even if it's 50, I've got musicians that may have been working with this guy, I don't want to make that further, and there's the audience. You care about the safety of everybody. So we cancelled the whole season, or the whole concert series. We were able to pay everybody for that, and we did our due diligence on that. Then within a week or so of that we applied for the Paycheck Protection Program and we were able to get that. We had an April concert which we couldn't do, but because of that we were able to pay everybody for that, for the April concert. So I think people need to understand that as a musician every gig counts. You know this is not like sitting on, it's what they call now the "gig economy." It's like you're looking for the next gig. It's like my first statement to you where I said I pick up the phone, "I can do it." You know, and that's where most of the guys in my band that I lead, the Columbus Jazz Orchestra, "Hey are we going to get an April payment" you know. And it's so great that we could do that. But now I've cancelled a summer series. We played four concerts and with a rehearsal for each one of those for the guys, and I had to tell everybody that's gone too. Now the decision I made, I apologize for keep interrupting, the decision I've made is we're supposed to start in October with our new season — and I think we're going to start in December. But what CNN told me yesterday, along with Fauci and Sanjay Gupta was we're getting worse, we're not getting better. So are people comfortable social distancing in December? That's why I've made that either livestream or television broadcast, but I still am going to have to social distance my musicians when they play, and it goes on. I also am the principal pops conductor with the Pittsburgh Symphony. And so in that role I was supposed to do my debut concert with them in October and they've told me that everything is on hold. But Pittsburgh liked what I've done with my organization — it's we're not going to just shut down. There are organizations like the National Symphony who I've worked with a lot, and other orchestras that said we're just done until — just cut it off.

MR: Yeah. It would be a double whammy if you scheduled something even way down the line and then had to cancel it again.

BS: Yes. And that's why my backup is that we're able to do things virtually with the band. I think that — see because nonprofits work off of season ticket sales. That's your base of your foundation and money, in addition to donations and stuff. By the way, people are amazingly generous. I mean we've had people write checks to us for tens of thousands of dollars. That's when my dad and my mom always said it pays to be nice to people. You

MR: It also pays, you must have been presenting quality entertainment over the years, you know.

BS: Yes, we have. And you know the band has been in existence about 47, 48 years, we'll be celebrating our 50th soon. But that's what we're supposed to do. That's a given. But it also, you have to thank people, you have to acknowledge their gift to you because most people don't know, and I'll stop yacking my tongue now but most people don't know that the arts are sustained through donations. I mean that's why, I forgot, the first thing you said to me, and I realized they were important, was when you introduced me is this is the something something Hamilton College, what are those people's —

MR: Fillius Jazz Archive.

BS: Right. Those people are why you and I sit here.

MR: Right.

BS: And so I think it's important to acknowledge that you know, and thank you. You're supposed to do that, but I know that you do that from your heart too, that that's real. And it's real to me and that's why I wanted to have you say their name one more time because I don't forget that.

MR: Okay. Well it's a little ironic, I was thinking about last November for some reason was a particularly bad month for me and my cohorts gig-wise. And now those are the good old days.

BS: Oh gosh. Yeah. You know it's up to, the hardest part about being an artist or a musician I think is the creation, the continuous creation of art and we have to look at this time as that's another part of the gift, to get ourselves physically together, that's why I try to walk as much as I can every day. We've been doing about two miles a day. Not a lot and I should do more. You know and try to eat right. But then getting down into making yourself better as an artist — all that stuff that you want to give to people, that you know that our job is to lift them up. That there is hope in the darkness. And we can provide that hope through the music, because music can lift people. And that's why, during, we've talked a lot about civil rights and protesting, during the Civil Rights Era it was the music that made people get up and march. And so during the Montgomery bus boycott one of the things Martin Luther King did during that period of time is he said before I speak, and sometimes they would have church every night because he knew that would energize people, right? And imagine like going, deciding I'm not going to go on the bus, but that means I have to walk an hour to work. And so King said before I even speak — when we have church every night before I even speak we're going to sing for like twenty minutes. You know what they sang? "Nobody Knows the Trouble I've Seen." But they also sang "I'm Gonna Move On Up a Little Higher." They also sang, "I Ain't Gonna Let Nobody

talked about sho's you're born." But then they'd say, "I'm going to ride that glory train/the only way for me to get to heaven is to ride that glory train." And they would clap their hands and there was the physiology about the movement and the physical act of singing that brings joy. And that's what I'm charged to do, what we're charged to do as musicians, is to bring that joy in the sense of music. And it can be non, even non-verbal is better. I was working with the Pittsburgh Symphony recently and some of their donors and just having a conversation with them and I asked one of the guys I said, "What's one of your best musical experiences." And he said, "You know I'm a very religious man," he says, "but I have to tell you the best experiences, the peak experiences that I've had in my life have been in the concert hall watching the Pittsburgh Symphony, not necessarily having, you know what I'm saying? So this is the power of music and I think we have to hone our focus on that and as Bernstein said play more devotedly and perform even harder than we ever have before, to squeeze the juice out of the joy and the majesty of great jazz and great music. And that's the thing. Because the artists can lead where we're going in this revolution, getting out of Covid. We have to lead it.

MR: Wow, well thank you, Byron. There's some eloquent statements there, and I really appreciate your sharing your opinions.

BS: What a joy to talk to you again. I want to just congratulate you and thank you for what you're doing for the history of jazz, and that will be a document that you created along with your sponsors, that will outlive both of us, and I'm happy to see that.

MR: Thank you. It has been a great gig for me, I'll give you that.

BS: Well you're great at it. I was listening to the Loren Schoenburg interview, you're great at it, so thank you.

MR: Well I'm going to pause our recording, then we can just wrap up.